The .env File

Keeping secrets out of your repository

Where do your keys live?

.env

Local settings your code reads and git ignores

What Goes in One

Setting	Example value
An API key	sk-live-4f9c2a...
A database URL	postgres://user:pw@host
A signing token	A long random string
A per-machine path	/Users/you/data

Ignore It Before You Write It

Add .env to .gitignore first

Then create the file

Never the other way round

One slip and it is in history

Commit an Example Instead

A file named .env.example

Every key name, no values

Committed on purpose

So a teammate knows what to set

On GitHub

The .env file never goes up

Actions read repository secrets

Per-environment secrets for deploys

Never print one into the log

If It Is Already Pushed

Rotate the key first, right now

Deleting the file is not enough

Your history still holds it

Assume it was already read

Where Each Value Lives

Place	How it is stored
Your laptop	A .env file, ignored
A pull request	Nothing at all
GitHub Actions	Repository secrets
Production	The host's secret store

Before You Push

Is .env in .gitignore?

Does git status show it?

Is .env.example up to date?

Would you show this diff to anyone?